

THE SCIENCE OF FLAVOR

To identify the flavor of the tea you are drinking, the brain calls on taste stimuli from receptors on the tongue, olfactory stimuli from the nasal passage, and the textural and thermal sensations you experience while drinking.

There are hundreds of different flavor compounds in tea, but the average person can categorize only a few. With some concentration and a little experience, it is possible to train your brain to identify them. Take a look at the flavor wheel on pages 50–51 to identify some of the key flavors in tea.

SENSES

When thinking about identifying flavors, it is important to understand how senses work with one another. The cup illustration, right, helps you to understand how texture and taste work together to form your experience of astringency in the cup. Likewise taste and smell do not exist in isolation, but rather meet within the olfactory system to give you the experience of flavor.

TEMPERATURE

Temperature plays an important role in the sensory perception of tea. When tea is hot, aromas evaporate more quickly and certain layers of flavor disappear from the cup as it cools. Studies have shown that the tongue detects more astringency in a hot drink than a cool one, so it would benefit your experience of tasting delicately flavored teas, such as white tea, to let them cool slightly before attempting to identify flavors.

FLAVOR

Flavor is the combination of smell and taste, and this is what we experience when eating or drinking. Taste is closely tied to smell—75 percent of what we taste is determined by smell. Volatile aromatic oils in tea evaporate and rise into our nasal passages as we sip, creating flavors that can only be detected when the senses of smell and taste work together.

SMELL

Even before you sip tea, you will notice its aroma. While it is hot, you will smell wafts of the tea's bouquet in the air near the surface of the liquid. As you bring your nose close to the surface of the tea and sniff, you will engage the olfactory system. After inhaling, exhale through your nose. Aromas linger in the nasal passage, preparing your senses for the experience of taste inside your mouth.

